

# Data-Driven Insights in shaping Market-Entry Decisions and Entrepreneurial Strategies

Research Proposal Submitted to AF Lindstedt Fund in April 2025

|                                |                                                                    |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Duration of Proposed Research: | 1 <sup>st</sup> July 2025 to 31 <sup>st</sup> Dec 2026 (18 months) |
| Hosting Organization:          | Arcada University of Applied Sciences                              |
| Topic of Research:             | Data-Driven Insights for Strategic Decision-making                 |
| Requested Funds                | € 69784                                                            |

## Executive Summary

The global business landscape is undergoing a transformation: Significant recent advancements in data analytics tools and in AI techniques now present novel opportunities for entrepreneurs to use AI and data analytics for gaining a deeper understanding of their target markets, identify consumer needs, and make strategic decisions grounded in evidence rather than in intuition. But before business leaders and entrepreneurs leverage this promise of AI and analytics, there is a significant need for a rigorous inquiry into how these insights can be effectively utilized across various stages of their business cycles and the entrepreneurial journey. This inquiry will define the role of data-driven insights in shaping entrepreneurial strategies and market entry decisions.

However, such an investigation would be too broad. We face a plethora of business contexts, varied industrial domains and innumerable intended target products; the sheer variety and size of the target would be overwhelming. We narrow our objective to specifically focus on simulated (software) digital twins for large-cap industrial organizations. Separate TUF funds have already been approved for the technical investigation of digital twins. Major Finnish companies (Example: Fortum Oy) are actively collaborating with researchers at Arcada UAS to develop digital twins.

We now request AF Lindstedt for separate funds to support a comprehensive 18-month business research project that will assist business leaders to effectively use AI and data analytics for strategic decision-making. The proposed research will address how business analytics can help explore emerging market opportunities and how AI can help identify consumer needs. The funds will be used for data collection, market analysis, semi-structured interviews with industry experts, in-depth case studies of successful companies, establishment of robust data analytics practices for customer acquisition and the final dissemination of findings through conferences and publications. Besides assisting with the business aims of the Arcada researchers (working on digital twins), this new research will yield valuable findings for the wider business community.

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# 1. Introduction

## 1.1. Background

Over the last two decades, the global business landscape has seen a major paradigm shift. Significant advancements in analytical tools and computational techniques are coupled with the exponential increase in the volume and variety of data available. These twin factors lead to a novel opportunity: Business leaders and entrepreneurs can now use a wide range of modern tools to gain a deeper understanding of their target markets, to identify unmet consumer needs and hence to make strategic decisions based on data-based-evidence instead of intuition-based traditional thinking alone<sup>1</sup>. Such data-driven insights can potentially revolutionize the entrepreneurial process and the business cycle by affecting decision of opportunity identification and market entry. While potential or this promise of data analytics has been discussed extensively, the relevant literature lacks the rigorous academic inquiry into *how*, *when* and *where* these insights can be most effectively utilized<sup>6</sup>. Across various stages of the business and entrepreneurial journey and across different industry sectors, business leaders face challenges in identifying the most effective practices in harnessing the power of data analytics for strategic advantage<sup>8</sup>. We summarize the open challenges and questions as follows:

1. How can business analytics and AI-powered tools identify unmet consumer needs and emerging market opportunities across various industries?
2. How can machine learning and predictive modelling assist with forecasting of market trends to assess the viability of new product or service ideas?
3. How can data from diverse sources (e.g., social media, market research reports, competitor analysis) be integrated to inform decision-making?
4. What are the best practices for start-ups and established businesses in leveraging data analytics for effective market segmentation and targeted customer acquisition strategies.
5. Are there any ethical considerations and data privacy implications of using advanced analytics in entrepreneurial ventures?
6. Can a set of case studies illustrate the success of companies in leveraging data analytics to achieve significant market success?

## 1.2. Aims of the business research project

As the reliance on advanced analytical techniques grows, there emerges a need for a robust framework to harness the practical application of these insights. Such a framework will enhance the likelihood of entrepreneurial success, guide business leaders in effectively utilizing the emerging technologies and will assist business schools to educate students on the practical application of data-driven insights in business decision-making<sup>10</sup>. To address these challenges and to answer the open questions, we propose an 18-month research with the following aims:

1. Conduct a detailed analysis of the capabilities of business analytics and artificial intelligence in identifying unmet consumer needs and emerging market opportunities across.
2. Rigorously research the effectiveness and inherent limitations of machine learning and predictive modelling techniques in the context of forecasting market trends and assessing the viability of novel product or service concepts.

3. Thoroughly explore the diverse methodologies and technologies for integrating data from disparate sources to provide comprehensive insights for entrepreneurial decision-making.
4. Systematically investigate the specific challenges encountered by both start-ups and established businesses in leveraging data analytics for market segmentation and customer acquisition, and to document the most effective practices for overcoming these hurdles.
5. Critically examine the ethical considerations and the significant data privacy implications associated with the increasing use of advanced analytics within entrepreneurial ventures.
6. Develop a comprehensive and practical curriculum framework that business schools can adopt to effectively educate PhD students on the application of data-driven insights within the domains of entrepreneurship and market analysis.
7. Conduct a series of in-depth case studies of companies that have demonstrably achieved significant market success through the strategic application of data analytics.

### 1.3. Identifying a specific target product for the research

The proposed research on this topic would be hindered by the vast breadth of business landscape and the sheer overabundance in the options available. Theoretically, this business research could address every single facet of human activity. To make better use of our efforts, we need to narrow the focus of enquiry to a specific domain and to one specific target product. Further, it makes sense to select the specific domain and the specific target product where the researchers have current in-depth knowledge, useful contacts with relevant practitioners and a direct way to implement some business decisions (hence recording the outcomes of our actions).

Fortunately, an excellent candidate business target is available: Researchers at Arcada University of Applied Sciences have been working on the design and development of a product named “simulated digital twins”. A simulated digital twin is a computational model of a real-life product, process or service that enables simulated experimentation, virtual exploration of scenarios and hence decision-making without any physical actions. Several major Finnish companies (Example: Fortum Oy, Wärtsilä Technologies, Sandvik AB) are actively collaborating with the researchers at Arcada UAS to develop simulated digital twins. TUF has recently approved funds for the technical investigation of simulated digital twins. This endeavour is now crossing the proof-of-concept stage from a technology maturity perspective; the next milestone is to offer digital twins as a commercial product. Success of this software product (digital twin) now requires business analytics and strategic decisions on *how*, *when* and *where* should this product be marketed.

**Clarification:** The research proposed by this document is the **business** research on how strategic business decisions should be made for *any* new product. Simulated digital twins will merely be the use-case on which these business strategies will be explored and implemented. This document does not request any funds for the “technical” research of simulated digital twins.

Selection of this target (simulated digital twins) uniquely addresses the aims of the business research proposal as explained in Section 1.2 earlier. Primarily, the researchers at Arcada University of Applied Sciences have direct contact and ongoing collaborations with practitioners from various industries. This provides a reliable mechanism for identifying and convincing relevant business leaders from key industries to participate in semi-structured interviews, case studies and other discussions for business research and strategy formation. In absence of such contacts,

it is a major challenge for business researchers at universities to get focussed time and efforts for competent business leaders. Secondly, since the product is in-house, the results of the business decisions made for the digital twin product can be meticulously known, studied and reported as part of the business research project. Finally, the convergence of technology experts (who will use TUF funds on the technical product development) and the business researchers (who will use Lindstedt funds for the business research) leads to a synergy of skillsets that could potentially build a new paradigm for future research at Arcada.

**Kindly note:** This document solely concerns the business-oriented research for using data analytics in corporate decision-making. While we do mention digital twins in this document, our application to Lindstedt here is not regarding the technical coding for digital twins. Digital twin is merely the *first* test-case product on which we test our business strategies. Digital twins are not the focus of this document. Hence, this document will not discuss digital twins any further.

#### **1.4. Teaching impact of this project**

Arcada UAS is primarily a teaching institution. The researchers and staff members who will work on this proposed research project are existing teachers and lecturers at Arcada. So, this research project will also be used as a teaching opportunity whereby students at Arcada UAS will gain valuable hands-on experience from observation and participation. Moreover, the Ph.D. student (that is proposed to be included within this research project) will also be expected to share the newly acquired skills via case study sessions for other students.

## **2. Literature Review**

The global market for artificial intelligence is experiencing remarkable expansion, with projections indicating a total size of USD 3,680.47 billion by the year 2034, representing a robust compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 19.20% from 2025 to 2034.<sup>15</sup> While North America currently holds the largest share of the AI market, the Asia Pacific region is anticipated to exhibit the highest CAGR during the forecast period.<sup>15</sup> In this entire discussion, the Nordics region and especially Finland is notably less conspicuous. To be relevant in the global market and to ensure that Finnish society is at the forefront of this ongoing expansion, we need the proper tools, frameworks and context. Our research project will take a major step towards this objective. In this Section, we review the available literature and identify gaps where our research will focus.

### **2.1 Identifying market opportunities based on Unmet needs**

We begin the review of the existing literature by analysing how business analytics and AI-powered tools can identify unmet consumer needs and emerging market opportunities across various industries. The identification of unmet consumer needs is a cornerstone of successful business strategy, serving as the impetus for the development of innovative products and services that resonate with customer expectations, foster loyalty, and drive revenue growth.<sup>12</sup> Feedback from consumers, even in the form of criticisms, can offer invaluable clues for businesses seeking to understand where their offerings fall short.<sup>12</sup> A proactive approach to uncovering these needs is essential for maintaining a competitive edge in today's dynamic marketplace. Generative research methodologies, employing qualitative techniques such as

diary studies, digital ethnography, and in-depth user interviews, are particularly effective in generating fresh perspectives and identifying previously unrecognized user and customer needs, thereby paving the way for product and experience innovation.<sup>12</sup> Digital ethnography provides a powerful lens for remotely observing and researching individuals within the context of their daily lives, yielding a deep understanding of their behaviours, values, and beliefs, which is crucial for discerning unmet needs in their natural environment.<sup>12</sup> Diary studies, which involve participants recording their experiences with products or services over time, enable companies to gather rich, nuanced data that can instantly highlight unmet needs and areas for improvement.<sup>12</sup> These needs often manifest as a lack of desired features, a suboptimal user experience, or prohibitive costs associated with existing solutions.<sup>12</sup> Cultivating empathy for the consumer is paramount in the process of uncovering these often-unarticulated needs.<sup>12</sup>

The concept of unmet needs extends beyond mere product functionalities to encompass fundamental social determinants of health and well-being, such as access to adequate food, safe housing, and reliable transportation.<sup>13</sup> Advanced analytical techniques can play a crucial role in demonstrating the relative significance of different unmet social needs within specific populations, allowing for more targeted and effective interventions.<sup>13</sup> Notably, consumers who exhibit higher utilization of healthcare services are more likely to report experiencing unmet social needs, suggesting a strong interconnectedness between individuals' social context and their engagement with essential services.<sup>13</sup>

After data collection, we move to a more profound analysis of customer perceptions, underlying needs, and expressed preferences.<sup>6</sup> Technologies such as speech and text analytics offer the capability to extract previously hidden insights by linguistically evaluating unstructured data, such as customer reviews and social media posts.<sup>6</sup> Understanding the narratives that customers construct around their experiences is also critical, as these narratives significantly influence their beliefs and behaviours, even if they are not entirely accurate.<sup>6</sup> A variety of methods can be employed for customer needs analysis, including primary research initiatives, surveys, in-depth interviews, focus group discussions, and the systematic collection of customer feedback.<sup>6</sup> Social media platforms serve as valuable channels for obtaining real-time feedback directly from consumers.<sup>6</sup> Furthermore, analysing audience data from social media posts can provide direct insights into expressed customer needs and emerging trends.<sup>6</sup> The practice of "listening in" to online dialogues between customers and virtual advisors represents a practical marketing research methodology for identifying new segments of consumers with high-potential unmet needs, particularly in markets characterized by a large number of options and diverse customer requirements.<sup>7</sup> Needs-based analysis, which focuses on understanding why consumers make purchases and how they utilize those purchases, lies at the intersection of product marketing and new product development.<sup>7</sup> Businesses have a significant interest in proactively identifying customer needs that are currently unmet and in anticipating future needs, as this can provide them with a crucial first-mover advantage in emerging markets and significantly enhance their overall profitability.<sup>7</sup> Computational approaches for extracting customer needs from user-generated content are increasingly being explored as valuable complements to traditional research methods.<sup>7</sup> Quantifying unmet customer needs involves understanding desired outcome statements, which articulate how customers define success when completing a particular task.<sup>14</sup> The Opportunity Algorithm, which calculates an opportunity score based on the importance and

satisfaction levels of desired outcomes, provides a framework for quantifying these unmet needs.<sup>14</sup> Outcomes that are highly important to customers but poorly satisfied represent significant opportunities for value creation, while outcomes that are well-satisfied but not particularly important may be targets for cost reduction.<sup>14</sup>

AI-powered tools are transforming the landscape of market research and opportunity identification by leveraging advanced algorithms to analyse trends, track competitive activities, and provide data-driven insights that facilitate informed decision-making and the prediction of market shifts with remarkable speed and accuracy.<sup>3</sup> The functionalities offered by AI market research tools include real-time data collection from multiple sources, advanced data analysis to uncover hidden patterns, predictive analytics to forecast future market movements, granular audience segmentation for targeted marketing, comprehensive competitor analysis to understand the competitive landscape, sentiment analysis to gauge public opinion, significant time and cost efficiencies in the research process, and ultimately, enhanced decision-making capabilities.<sup>3</sup> A variety of AI-powered platforms and tools are available to businesses, including versatile options like ChatGPT and Perplexity AI, specialized market intelligence platforms like Cove AI, and AI-enhanced survey tools like Qualtrics XM and SurveyMonkey Genius.<sup>3</sup>

## **2.2 Predictive Analytics in Business**

We now move to researching the application of machine learning and predictive modeling in forecasting market trends and assessing the viability of new product or service ideas. Market share analysis provides valuable insights into the competitive landscape, enabling researchers to evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of different players, monitor evolving trends driven by changing consumer preferences, and develop forecasts for future market dynamics based on historical data.<sup>1</sup> The shift from traditional analytical methods to data-driven approaches is facilitated by advancements in technology and data science, making predictive forecasting using big data, artificial intelligence, and customized metrics increasingly feasible.<sup>1</sup> The integration of big data into market share analysis significantly enhances the depth and breadth of information available, enriching the quality of insights obtained through sophisticated data collection techniques.<sup>1</sup> The development of custom metrics offers enhanced precision in measuring the specific factors that directly influence market share and allows for the isolation and analysis of particular market trends that might be overlooked by generic metrics.<sup>1</sup> Data-driven marketing represents a paradigm shift in how businesses engage with their customers, focusing on the strategic use of detailed insights derived from customer behavior, market trends, and the performance of marketing campaigns to inform decision-making processes.<sup>4</sup> Data analytics plays an increasingly significant role in shaping market trends by enabling companies to leverage vast amounts of data to identify emerging patterns in consumer behavior and to adapt swiftly to changing market dynamics.<sup>2</sup> Predictive analytics, a key component of data analytics, employs statistical models and sophisticated forecasting tools to evaluate the likelihood of potential future outcomes.<sup>2</sup> Artificial intelligence market research tools offer the capability to assist businesses in predicting future market shifts and identifying emerging opportunities.<sup>3</sup> Furthermore, AI-powered tools provide predictive analytics functionalities that can yield valuable market insights, enabling more informed strategic planning.<sup>3</sup> A significant proportion of market researchers anticipate that AI will surpass the accuracy of human analysts in predicting market



trends within the next three years, underscoring the growing confidence in these technologies.<sup>18</sup> Artificial intelligence is fundamentally transforming the field of marketing by enabling brands to deliver highly personalized customer experiences and to better anticipate shifts in the market through the application of predictive insights derived from vast amounts of customer data.<sup>19</sup> AI-powered tools are also being increasingly utilized for trend analysis, providing businesses with a substantial competitive advantage by enabling them to identify and capitalize on emerging trends early.<sup>20</sup> A range of AI techniques are employed in trend analysis, including predictive analytics to forecast future trends, data mining to discover hidden patterns, Natural Language Processing (NLP) to understand textual data, deep learning and neural networks to model complex relationships, time series analysis to analyze data over time, and sentiment analysis to gauge public opinion.<sup>21</sup> AI trend analysis tools empower businesses to make data-driven decisions and accurately predict potential challenges by identifying and analyzing temporal patterns in collected data.<sup>22</sup> Machine learning algorithms are increasingly being applied in the prediction of stock market trends, aiming to overcome the limitations of traditional analytical methods and leverage the power of data-driven approaches to capture the intricate dynamics of the market and enhance the accuracy of predictions.<sup>23</sup> A variety of machine learning models are employed in stock market forecasting, including straightforward yet effective techniques like linear regression, powerful classification models like Support Vector Machines (SVMs), versatile ensemble methods like decision trees and Random Forests, and sophisticated deep learning architectures such as Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs) and Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs).<sup>23</sup> The process of feature selection and engineering, which involves carefully choosing and transforming relevant input variables such as financial indicators, macroeconomic variables, and sentiment analysis data, plays a crucial role in enhancing the predictive capabilities of machine learning models for market forecasting.<sup>24</sup>

Machine learning and predictive modeling offer a robust set of tools for entrepreneurs to rigorously assess the viability of their new product or service ideas. By analyzing historical data, simulating potential market responses, and forecasting likely outcomes, these techniques allow for more data-informed decisions to be made before significant financial and operational resources are committed, thereby reducing the inherent risks associated with launching new ventures. Applying machine learning algorithms to data derived from past product launches, comprehensive market research studies, and even real-time sentiment analysis from social media platforms enables entrepreneurs to build sophisticated models that can predict the potential for success of their new offerings, ultimately facilitating data-driven go/no-go decisions.

## **2.3 Role of Data in Decision Making**

Next, we explore how data from diverse sources (e.g., social media, market research reports, competitor analysis) can be integrated to inform entrepreneurial decision-making. A variety of data integration approaches are available to businesses, each with its own set of characteristics and suitability for different scenarios. Application integration involves the use of specialized software programs to manage the entire data integration process, from identifying and retrieving data to cleaning and combining it from multiple disparate sources.<sup>44</sup> Manual data integration, as the name suggests, relies on a data manager to manually complete the entire integration process, including writing code, aggregating data sources, and cleaning the data before storage.<sup>45</sup>



Middleware data integration utilizes software that acts as a bridge between different applications, databases, and tools, facilitating the movement, cleaning, and validation of data before storage in a unified location.<sup>45</sup> Uniform access integration presents data from heterogeneous sources in a consistent manner while simultaneously storing it in its original location, reducing storage costs but potentially posing data integrity risks.<sup>45</sup> Common storage integration refines this approach by creating and storing a copy of the data from various sources in a central repository, promoting cleaner data and simplifying data access for business intelligence analytics.<sup>45</sup> Other frequently used data integration techniques include data orchestration, which involves the automated coordination of data integration workflows, data consolidation, which focuses on aggregating data from multiple sources into a centralized repository such as a data warehouse or data lake, and hybrid data integration, which combines on-premises and cloud-based integration solutions.<sup>45</sup> The primary goal of data integration is to consolidate data from various sources into a single, unified view, thereby enabling businesses to derive actionable insights and make decisions based on comprehensive and standardized information.<sup>47</sup> Strategies for achieving effective data integration include data federation, also known as virtual data integration, which allows organizations to access and query data in real-time from multiple sources without physically moving or replicating it.<sup>46</sup> Data transformation involves the crucial steps of cleansing, normalizing, and converting data from its original format into a target format suitable for downstream analytical processes.<sup>46</sup> Data propagation, which encompasses techniques like data replication and ETL (Extract, Transform, Load), involves copying data from one location to another, either in real-time or at scheduled intervals.<sup>46</sup> APIs (Application Programming Interfaces) play a vital role in facilitating seamless communication and the real-time exchange of data between different software applications and systems, often without requiring extensive manual coding.<sup>49</sup> ETL (Extract, Transform, Load) and its counterpart, ELT (Extract, Load, Transform), represent two common data integration strategies focused on the movement of data between source and destination systems, with ELT performing the data transformation step directly within the data warehouse.<sup>46</sup>

A variety of social media analytics tools, such as Google Analytics, AIM Insights, and Sprout Social, empower businesses to effectively monitor their social media activities, conduct in-depth analyses of performance, and respond strategically to emerging trends and customer feedback.<sup>55</sup> Social media analytics provides valuable capabilities for tracking customer preferences, closely monitoring competitor activities, and understanding the overall perception of a brand within the online sphere, offering crucial insights for tailoring marketing strategies and guiding product development initiatives.<sup>56</sup> MIS (Management Information System) plays a pivotal role in centralizing social media data, ensuring its accessibility for analysis, and providing real-time reporting functionalities that support agile and informed decision-making processes.<sup>56</sup> Social media market research involves systematically gathering data and extracting valuable insights about a business's target audience, its competitors, and prevailing industry trends directly from social media platforms, offering a faster, more affordable, and highly scalable approach compared to traditional market research methodologies.<sup>57</sup> Social listening tools, such as Brandwatch, are instrumental in this process, enabling entrepreneurs to effectively monitor relevant hashtags, keywords, and brand mentions across various social media platforms to identify recurring themes and understand the sentiment within online conversations.<sup>57</sup>

Market research reports represent another valuable source of data that, when effectively integrated with other sources, can significantly enhance entrepreneurial decision-making.<sup>50</sup> Data integration in the context of market research involves the process of systematically combining data from a variety of sources, including formal market research reports, into a cohesive and unified framework that supports comprehensive analysis and facilitates well-informed strategic decisions.<sup>59</sup> Several effective strategies can be employed for integrating market research reports with other relevant data, including the creation of centralized data systems that consolidate information from disparate sources, the utilization of APIs to enable real-time communication and data exchange between different systems, the implementation of automated data pipelines to streamline the flow of data and ensure consistency, and the fostering of collaborative data practices across different departments within an organization.<sup>59</sup> The initial step in any successful data integration effort involves carefully identifying which specific data sources are most relevant to the business's goals and objectives, which can include various formats such as relational databases, flat files, XML and JSON documents, data accessible through APIs, cloud-based data repositories, and even data generated by Internet of Things (IoT) devices.<sup>50</sup> The integration of data analytics with the findings presented in market research reports allows for a deeper and more nuanced understanding of consumer behavior patterns, evolving preferences, and prevailing market trends, ultimately leading to the development of more effective and data-driven strategic initiatives.<sup>60</sup> Market research itself provides both qualitative and quantitative information regarding consumer behavior, preferences, and broader market trends, serving as a foundational baseline upon which more advanced analytical techniques can be applied to identify underlying patterns and predict future behaviors with greater accuracy.<sup>60</sup> Combining primary research efforts, which involve the direct collection of data from sources such as surveys and interviews, with secondary research sources, such as published market research reports and industry analyses, offers a comprehensive and well-rounded view of the overall market landscape, enabling organizations of all sizes to uncover previously unnoticed unmet consumer needs and identify emerging market niches and opportunities.<sup>61</sup>

## **2.4 Leveraging Data Analytics**

Next, we investigate the challenges and best practices for start-ups and established businesses in leveraging data analytics for effective market segmentation and targeted customer acquisition strategies. Market segmentation analysis is a fundamental marketing technique that involves dividing a broad and heterogeneous target market into smaller, more homogeneous categories of consumers based on shared characteristics, with the ultimate goal of tailoring marketing efforts and improving both customer acquisition and retention rates.<sup>8</sup> Several common types of market segmentation are utilized by businesses, including demographic segmentation based on factors like age and income, geographic segmentation based on location, psychographic segmentation based on lifestyle and values, behavioral segmentation based on product usage, firmographic segmentation for B2B markets, and technographic segmentation based on technology adoption.<sup>8</sup> Start-ups often encounter a range of challenges when attempting to leverage data analytics for effective market segmentation, including limitations in the availability and accuracy of data, the potential for over-segmentation leading to overly complex marketing strategies, the issue of static segmentation becoming quickly outdated in dynamic markets,

difficulties in accurately measuring the effectiveness of segmentation efforts, a lack of true personalization despite segmentation efforts, and concerns related to compliance and data privacy in the collection and use of customer data for segmentation purposes.<sup>8</sup> Common pitfalls for start-ups in this area include failing to segment their market at all, creating too many small and unviable segments, under-segmenting into overly broad and less meaningful groups, basing segmentation on superficial or irrelevant criteria that do not significantly influence purchasing decisions, and overlooking the actual size and potential of identified market segments.<sup>70</sup> Inaccurate or inadequate market segmentation can have a number of detrimental effects on a start-up's marketing efforts, including diluted messaging that fails to resonate with any specific group, missed opportunities to effectively target niche customer needs, a waste of limited marketing budgets on ineffective campaigns, reduced levels of customer satisfaction and loyalty due to a misalignment of offerings with expectations, and ultimately, a slower rate of overall business growth.<sup>70</sup>

Targeted customer acquisition is a critical objective for both start-ups and established businesses, and data-driven marketing plays an increasingly vital role in achieving this goal by leveraging data analytics to gain a deep understanding of consumer behavior, preferences, and trends, thereby enabling more focused and personalized marketing initiatives.<sup>72</sup> Key elements of a successful data-driven marketing strategy for customer acquisition include the effective use of predictive analytics to anticipate future customer behavior and the implementation of personalization techniques to tailor marketing messages and offers to individual customer needs and preferences.<sup>72</sup> A fundamental best practice for effective customer acquisition is to develop a thorough understanding of the target audience, including their demographics, psychographics, behaviors, pain points, and the key factors that influence their decision-making processes.<sup>9</sup> Selecting the most appropriate acquisition channels that align with the target audience's preferences and behaviors, as well as the overall business objectives (such as building brand awareness, generating qualified leads, or driving direct sales), is also essential for maximizing reach and impact.<sup>9</sup> Leveraging technology, particularly the power of artificial intelligence and machine learning, can significantly enhance customer acquisition efforts by optimizing the selection of marketing channels, the timing of campaigns, and the overall deployment of marketing resources, especially in industries that are subject to specific regulations.<sup>74</sup> Continuously analyzing key performance metrics, such as the Cost per Acquisition (CPA), is crucial for evaluating the financial effectiveness of different acquisition strategies and for making data-driven adjustments to improve overall performance and return on investment.<sup>73</sup> Best practices for implementing data-driven customer acquisition include integrating data from various relevant sources (such as CRM systems, social media platforms, and third-party data providers), personalizing marketing messages and offers to increase their relevance, conducting rigorous A/B testing to determine which versions of marketing materials and channels resonate most effectively with the target audience, utilizing look-alike modeling to identify new potential customers who share key characteristics with existing high-value customers, and carefully mapping the customer journey to identify critical touchpoints where data can be leveraged to enhance the acquisition process.<sup>74</sup> Customer analytics, which involves the systematic collection, analysis, and interpretation of customer data, both historical and predictive, helps businesses to better understand their customers, create more personalized solutions, identify their most

valuable customer segments, and optimize the overall customer journey to predict future behavior patterns.<sup>75</sup>

## **2.5 Ethical and Data-privacy implications**

We also examine the ethical considerations and data privacy implications of using advanced analytics in entrepreneurial ventures. The utilization of advanced analytics in entrepreneurial ventures brings forth a set of significant ethical considerations that extend beyond mere legal compliance, encompassing a fundamental commitment to fairness, transparency in data practices, accountability for data handling, and a deep respect for the privacy and fundamental rights of individuals.<sup>10</sup> Key ethical principles that entrepreneurial ventures must uphold include obtaining informed consent from individuals before collecting or utilizing their personal data, ensuring the privacy and security of collected data in compliance with relevant regulations such as the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and the California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA), maintaining transparency with customers regarding the methods of data collection, storage, and intended uses, striving for fairness in the application of analytics to avoid biases and discriminatory outcomes, and establishing clear lines of accountability for the handling of data and the consequences of its use.<sup>10</sup> Common ethical challenges that arise in the context of data analysis include potential breaches of privacy and the inadvertent exposure of sensitive personal information, the inherent risk of bias in both data collection processes and analytical algorithms that can lead to unfair or discriminatory results, the potential for the misuse of collected data and the misinterpretation of analytical findings, the critical need for obtaining informed consent from individuals regarding how their data will be used, and the overarching importance of ensuring transparency and accountability throughout the entire data lifecycle, from collection to decision-making.<sup>10</sup> Data analysts working within entrepreneurial ventures bear a significant responsibility to ensure the accuracy, integrity, and security of the data they handle, to diligently strive for objectivity and impartiality in their analytical work, and to maintain transparency with stakeholders regarding the limitations and uncertainties associated with their analyses.<sup>10</sup>

## **2.6 Framework for application of data-driven insights**

Next, we discuss the development of a framework for business schools to educate students on the practical application of data-driven insights in entrepreneurship and market analysis. Potential key elements that will be incorporated into this framework, drawing directly from the insights gleaned from the research snippets, include dedicated curriculum modules that specifically focus on the application of artificial intelligence and machine learning techniques for identifying promising market opportunities and gaining a deep understanding of evolving consumer behavior.<sup>3</sup> The framework will also emphasize practical training sessions on the effective utilization of various AI-powered market research tools and platforms, enabling students to gain hands-on experience in areas such as trend analysis, competitor intelligence gathering, and the analysis of customer sentiment expressed across various online channels.<sup>3</sup> Experiential learning will be a cornerstone of the framework, with students engaging in hands-on projects that require the application of machine learning and predictive modeling techniques for real-world tasks such as forecasting emerging market trends and rigorously assessing the viability of innovative new product or service ideas.<sup>23</sup> Furthermore, the framework will include

specialized workshops focusing on a variety of data integration techniques and strategic approaches for effectively combining data from diverse sources that are highly relevant to entrepreneurial decision-making, such as social media data, findings from formal market research reports, and comprehensive competitor intelligence.<sup>44</sup> In-depth analysis of carefully selected case studies of companies, inspired by successful examples like AI Palette, Amazon, and Netflix, that have strategically leveraged data analytics to achieve significant market success and drive innovation will also be a key component of the curriculum.<sup>86</sup> Recognizing the critical importance of responsible data practices, the framework will incorporate dedicated seminars and interactive discussions focusing on the complex ethical considerations and the significant data privacy implications associated with the use of advanced analytics in entrepreneurial ventures, emphasizing the need for responsible and robust data governance strategies.<sup>76</sup>

## **2.7 Case study analysis**

We conclude our literature review with a case study analysis of successful companies that have leveraged data analytics to achieve significant market success. Potential companies that will be included in the case study analysis -- drawing inspiration from the research snippets -- for a detailed examination of its AI-driven methodology with a focus on its data sources, proprietary algorithms, and the impact of its insights on product innovation and successful market entry. Amazon will be analyzed for its extensive and sophisticated utilization of machine learning and predictive analytics across its vast e-commerce operations and optimization of its complex global supply chain.<sup>86</sup> Netflix will be examined for its pioneering use of data analytics to understand intricate viewer behavior patterns, personalize content recommendations to individual users, inform its strategic decisions regarding content acquisition and creation, and optimize overall user engagement and long-term retention.<sup>86</sup> Starbucks will be studied as an example of a company that effectively employs machine learning to develop highly personalized offers and recommendations for its extensive customer base, with the primary goal of increasing customer loyalty and driving sales growth.<sup>86</sup> Tesla will be investigated for its innovative application of machine learning in the development and continuous improvement of its electric vehicles, particularly in critical areas such as its advanced autonomous driving system (Autopilot) and the optimization of overall vehicle performance based on the vast amounts of real-world driving data it collects.<sup>86</sup> Spotify will be analyzed for its successful leverage of machine learning algorithms to curate highly personalized music playlists, such as its widely popular "Discover Weekly," and for its data-driven approach to enhancing overall user experience and driving sustained engagement.<sup>87</sup> Walmart will be examined for its use of predictive analytics in optimizing its complex inventory management systems, accurately forecasting demand for a wide range of products, including new launches, and personalizing the shopping experiences of its millions of customers in the retail sector.<sup>35</sup> Gastrograph AI is a compelling example of a company that utilizes machine learning and sophisticated predictive algorithms to model intricate consumer flavor preferences, thereby assisting food and beverage companies in developing new products that are closely aligned with the tastes and preferences of their target audiences.<sup>91</sup>

### 3. Research Methodology

This research project will employ a mixed-methods research approach, strategically combining quantitative analysis of existing datasets with in-depth qualitative case study research. This approach is designed to provide a comprehensive and nuanced understanding of the complex interplay between data-driven insights and entrepreneurial success.

#### 3.1 Data Collection plan

The data collection plan for this project is as follows:

- **Primary Data:** To gain deeper insights into real-world practices and challenges, primary data will be collected through semi-structured interviews. These interviews will be conducted with a carefully selected group of industry experts, including experienced data scientists specializing in business applications, seasoned business analysts with a focus on entrepreneurial ventures, and successful entrepreneurs who have demonstrably utilized data analytics as a core component of their strategy. Interviews will be conducted with representatives from the identified case study companies to gather first-hand accounts.
- **Secondary Data:** A comprehensive and systematic review of existing secondary data will be conducted. This will include a wide range of sources such as academic literature published in peer-reviewed journals, in-depth industry reports providing analyses of market trends and technological advancements, detailed market research reports offering insights into consumer behavior and preferences, and publicly available data on companies that have successfully leveraged data analytics in their entrepreneurial journeys. Relevant data will be sourced from academic databases such as Scopus and Web of Science, as well as from industry-specific publications and reputable market research firms.

#### 3.2 Data Analysis Plan

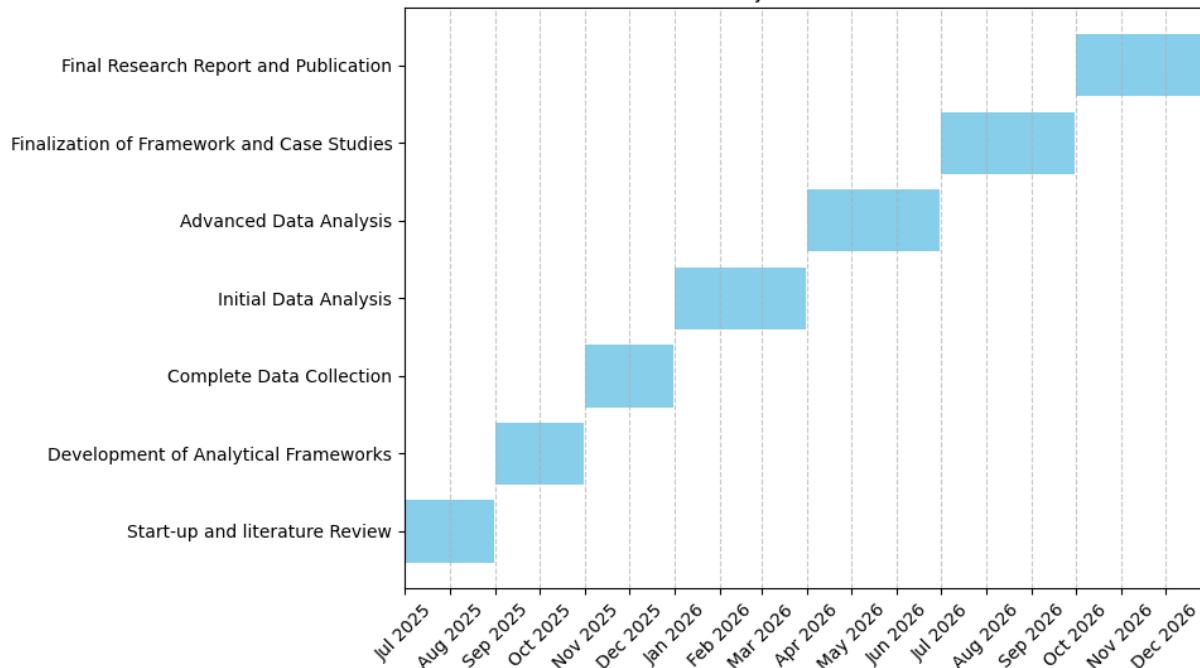
After collection, the data will be subjected to a detailed analysis phase as follows:

- **Quantitative Analysis:** Quantitative data, such as market trends, sales figures, and consumer behavior data extracted from secondary sources, will be analyzed using a variety of statistical techniques and machine learning algorithms. This analysis will aim to identify significant patterns, meaningful correlations, and predictive insights relevant to the research questions. Software tools such as R and Python, along with potentially specialized AI and machine learning platforms, will be utilized for these analyses.
- **Qualitative Analysis:** Qualitative data gathered from the semi-structured interviews and from the detailed case study materials will be analyzed using thematic analysis techniques. This process will involve systematically identifying recurring themes, prevalent best practices, key challenges encountered, and valuable lessons learned that are directly related to the research questions under investigation.



## 4. Project Timeline

We propose an 18-month project with the detailed timelines as illustrated in **Figure 1**.



**Figure 1: Project timelines across all phases**

The detailed plan for Year 1 is as follows:

- **Months 1-2:** A comprehensive and in-depth literature review will be undertaken, specifically addressing each of the seven research questions outlined in the proposal. This phase will focus on synthesizing existing knowledge, identifying key theoretical frameworks, and pinpointing significant gaps in the understanding of the research topic.
- **Months 3-4:** The research team will focus on the development of detailed analytical frameworks and specific methodologies for addressing each of the research questions. This will include the careful selection of appropriate data analysis techniques, the establishment of clear criteria for the selection of relevant case study companies, and the design of interview protocols for the primary data collection phase.
- **Months 5-6:** This phase will be dedicated to the collection of data. The primary focus will be on in-depth primary data collection. This will involve conducting the planned semi-structured interviews with representatives from the selected case study companies and with the identified industry experts. Extensive secondary data analysis will be conducted, and the process of identifying, recruiting, and establishing initial contact with potential case study companies and relevant industry experts will be initiated.
- **Months 7-9:** Initial analysis of the collected data will commence. This will include conducting preliminary quantitative analyses of secondary datasets and beginning the initial write-up of case studies based on publicly available secondary sources.
- **Months 10-12:** The research team will engage in advanced data analysis. This will include the development and rigorous validation of machine learning models specifically designed for



market trend forecasting and new product/service viability assessment. Furthermore, in-depth qualitative analysis of the interview transcripts and the comprehensive case study data will be conducted to extract key insights and findings.

The detailed plan for the 6 months of Year 2 is as follows:

- **Months 1-3:** Based on the research findings, the team will focus on the development of a practical and comprehensive educational framework specifically designed for business schools to effectively educate PhD students on the application of data-driven insights within the fields of entrepreneurship and market analysis.
- **Months 4-6:** The final phase of the project will be dedicated to the writing of the comprehensive research report, the dissemination of the key research findings through academic publications and conference presentations, and the finalization of all project outcomes, including the detailed case study compendium and the finalized educational framework for business schools.

## 5. Concrete Outcomes of the project

We foresee the following concrete outcomes of the research project:

- **Publications:** The project is expected to yield at least three high-quality, peer-reviewed academic publications that will be submitted to leading international journals in the fields of business analytics, entrepreneurship, and innovation. These publications will disseminate the core findings and theoretical contributions of the research to the academic community. A comprehensive and practically oriented industry report will be produced, synthesizing the key research findings into actionable insights for entrepreneurs, start-ups, and established businesses. This report will outline best practices for effectively leveraging data-driven insights in formulating entrepreneurial strategies and making informed market entry decisions, while also highlighting the common challenges and offering solutions.
- **Application Framework:** A detailed and practical framework will be developed for business schools to integrate the teaching of data-driven insights into their PhD programs in entrepreneurship and related disciplines. This framework will include specific recommendations for curriculum content, innovative pedagogical approaches, relevant case study materials, and potential assessment methods to ensure students gain both theoretical knowledge and practical skills.
- **Case Study Compendium:** A well-documented compendium of in-depth case studies of successful companies that have strategically leveraged data analytics to achieve significant market success and drive innovation will be created. This collection of real-world examples will serve as a valuable resource for both academic researchers and practitioners seeking to understand the application and impact of data-driven strategies in entrepreneurial contexts.
- **Conference Presentations:** The research findings will be presented at several national and international academic and industry conferences. This will provide opportunities to share the research with a wider audience, receive valuable feedback from peers and experts, and network with other professionals in the field.

## 6. Research Funding Requested from Lindstedt

We request a total fund of €69784 to execute this research. In this Section, we explain our budgeting, resourcing and our financial ask in terms of multiple tables and detailed calculations. The personnel resources (efforts) required across all phases are explained in **Table 1**. We note that the efforts listed for the Masters' or the Ph.D. students are not for one specific person each; the actual person working in this role may change depending on academic requirements and upon the skillsets and interests of the concerned candidate. However, the project will include the total efforts as listed below. We also point to the efforts marked for the external SME. They are the business leaders, entrepreneurs and subject matter experts who help us with the actual data and the use cases of specific domains relevant to our major customer organizations.

**Table 1: Effort (person hours) expected from participants**

| Person/Resource Name                                           | Efforts in Person Hours |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| Dr Niraj Ramesh (Principal Researcher)                         | <b>180</b>              |
| Dr Mark Dougherty (Dean for Research)                          | <b>20</b>               |
| Commercialization expert (Faculty member with business skills) | <b>65</b>               |
| Master's Student (MBA)                                         | <b>550</b>              |
| PhD Student (Business Analytics and Finance)                   | <b>375</b>              |
| Industry/Business leaders, External SMEs and consultants       | <b>100</b>              |

Next, we provide the commercial details of the overall expenses expected for the overall research project in **Table 2** below. Around 80% expenses arise from the (direct or indirect) salaries of the researchers working on this proposed research project. We include costs for business travels because we expect to collaborate with academic and industrial organizations across the Nordics.

**Table 2: Expense headings in overall budget**

| Expense Heading                         | Amount €     |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------|
| Direct wages of researchers             | <b>41690</b> |
| Administrative costs and indirect wages | <b>13956</b> |
| External SME expenses                   | <b>4388</b>  |
| Travel, conferences and publications    | <b>6000</b>  |
| Material purchases                      | <b>3750</b>  |
| <b>Total Funding Requested</b>          | <b>69784</b> |

The funds will be utilized for the researchers to work on data collection, market analysis, semi-structured interviews with industry experts, in-depth case studies of successful companies, establishment of robust data analytics practices for customer acquisition and the final dissemination of findings through conferences and publications.

## 7. Roles and Responsibilities of Team members

We discuss the roles and responsibilities of the members of the proposed team in **Table 3**.

**Table 3: Roles and Responsibilities of the Researchers**

| Role                   | Responsibility                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Principal Investigator | The PI is responsible for the overall execution of the research project, providing intellectual leadership and strategic guidance to the team.<br>The PI will oversee the research design and methodological choices, ensure the project remains on schedule and within budget                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| PhD Student            | The students will play a central role in the research process, primarily focusing on conducting the comprehensive and systematic literature reviews across all relevant research areas. They will also be heavily involved in performing the quantitative data analysis using statistical software and developing sophisticated machine learning models to address the research questions. Furthermore, they will contribute significantly to the writing of the academic publications and the final research report. |
| MBA Student            | As junior members, these students will primarily focus on assisting with the in-depth case study research, including the collection and analysis of data from various sources. They will also contribute to conducting market analysis to provide essential context for the overall research project and will play a valuable role in the development and refinement of the practical educational framework for business schools, leveraging their business acumen and understanding of pedagogical best practices.   |
| Industry leaders       | Suitable subject matter experts will serve as invaluable resources throughout the project, providing critical insights into the real-world applications of data analytics within entrepreneurial settings. They will participate in interviews to share their practical experiences, perspectives, and lessons learned. Their expertise will also be crucial in helping to validate the research findings and ensure their relevance and practical applicability to the business community.                           |

## 8. Connection to the strategic focus areas of Arcada/ Lindstedt

This research project has a clear and direct connection to the strategic focus areas of Arcada and to the priorities of Lindstedt fund (Lindstedts fond) for 2025 year. A detailed explanation of how our project supports these strategic areas and priorities is presented below:

### 8.1 Connection to the focus areas of Arcada University of Applied Sciences

- **Innovation and Practical Application:** Arcada University emphasizes innovation and the practical application of knowledge. Our project leverages cutting-edge data analytics and AI

tools to address real-world entrepreneurial challenges. By focusing on the practical application of data-driven insights, our research will contribute to Arcada's mission of fostering a culture of innovation and equipping students with the skills needed to thrive in a data-centric business environment. The development of an educational framework for business schools, which is a key outcome of our project, will further enhance Arcada's curriculum, ensuring that students are well-prepared to apply data analytics in their entrepreneurial endeavors.

- **Integration of Advanced Technologies:** Arcada's strategic focus includes the integration of advanced technologies in education and research. Our project aligns with this focus by employing sophisticated data analytics and AI methodologies to investigate entrepreneurial strategies and market entry decisions. This integration will not only advance academic knowledge but also provide practical tools and techniques that can be directly applied by students and researchers at Arcada.
- **Educational Excellence:** Arcada is committed to educational excellence and the continuous improvement of its programs. Our project will develop a comprehensive educational framework for business schools, including curriculum modules, practical training sessions, and experiential learning opportunities. This framework will ensure that Arcada's students gain both theoretical knowledge and practical skills in data-driven entrepreneurship, enhancing the overall quality and relevance of Arcada's educational offerings. Further, the researchers and the Ph.D. student working in the proposed research project will directly utilize the learnings from this project within their teaching tasks at Arcada. In fact, even the participant Ph.D. students are expected to share their learnings from the project as case studies for the wider Arcada student community.

## 8.2 Connection to the priorities of Lindstedt fund (Lindstedts fond)

- **Advancement of Business Education:** The Lindstedt Fund prioritizes projects that advance business education and support the development of practical skills in commerce and entrepreneurship. Our research proposal is perfectly aligned with these priorities, as it aims to develop actionable insights and best practices for leveraging data analytics in entrepreneurial decision-making. By addressing key research questions related to market opportunity identification, predictive modeling, data integration, and ethical considerations, our project will generate valuable knowledge that can be directly applied in business education and practice. We have already clarified how and when our learnings will be included in the teaching process at Arcada. Since the key participants of the proposed research project are lecturers and teachers at Arcada, all this knowledge will be eventually funnelled to the teaching activities.
- **Support for Practical Skills Development:** The Lindstedt Fund emphasizes the importance of practical skills development in business education. Our project includes the development of a detailed and practical framework for business schools to integrate the teaching of data-driven insights into their PhD programs in entrepreneurship and related disciplines. This framework will include specific recommendations for curriculum content, innovative pedagogical approaches, relevant case study materials, and potential assessment methods to ensure students gain both theoretical knowledge and practical skills.

- **Promotion of Ethical and Responsible Innovation:** The Lindstedt Fund values ethical considerations and responsible innovation in business practices. Our project will critically examine the ethical considerations and data privacy implications associated with the use of advanced analytics in entrepreneurial ventures. By developing a robust framework for responsible data practices and thereafter emphasizing the importance of ethical decision-making, our research supports Lindstedt Fund's commitment to promote ethical and responsible innovation.
- **Concrete Outcomes and Dissemination:** The Lindstedt Fund supports projects that produce tangible outcomes and disseminate findings to a wider audience. Our project is expected to yield high-quality academic publications, a comprehensive industry report, a detailed educational framework, and a well-documented compendium of case studies. These outcomes will be disseminated through academic publications, conference presentations, and industry reports, ensuring that the findings of our research are accessible and beneficial to both students and working practitioners.

In summary, our research project not only aligns with but also actively supports the strategic focus areas of Arcada and the priorities of the Lindstedt Fund by promoting innovation, practical application of data-driven insights, and the development of educational resources that prepare future entrepreneurs for success in a data-driven world.

## 9. Conclusion

This research project addresses a critical and increasingly important area in the fields of business analytics and entrepreneurship: the strategic role of data-driven insights in shaping entrepreneurial strategies and market entry decisions. By systematically investigating this topic through a rigorous mixed-methods approach, this project aims to provide valuable contributions to both academic knowledge and practical business applications. The comprehensive analysis of unmet consumer needs, the application of machine learning for forecasting, the integration of diverse data sources, the challenges and best practices in market segmentation and customer acquisition, and the ethical and data privacy considerations will provide a holistic understanding of the landscape. The development of an educational framework for business schools and the in-depth case study analysis of successful companies will offer practical guidance and real-world examples for future entrepreneurs and researchers. The collaborative nature of the research team, bringing together expertise from academia and industry, ensures that the project's outcomes will be both theoretically sound and practically relevant, ultimately fostering a more data-informed and strategic approach to new venture creation and sustainable growth.

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